The growing opium addiction among the Chinese people and their loss of silver to pay for opium imports led the Qing Daoguang emperor (reigned 1820–50) to assign a senior official – Lin Zexu, as Vice Governer of Canton – to implement an official ban on opium imports. Lin ordered the seizure of opium chests stored in warehouses in the British factories. These were then dumped into the ocean, setting off a chain of events culminating in the First Anglo-Chinese Opium War of 1839–42. This ended in the humiliating defeat of the Qing forces and the signing of the first of the ‘unequal treaties’, the Treaty of Nanjing, on 29 August 1842. China ceded the island of Hong Kong in the Pearl River delta to Britain and opened up four other ports on the Chinese coast to trade with Britain. These were Xiamen, Fuzhou, Ningbo and Shanghai. China agreed to pay a large indemnity, allow the import of opium, permit Christian missionary activity in the treaty ports and concede extraterritorial rights to British citizens operating in the treaty ports. This was the first of a series of setbacks for China over the next 100 years, not only at the hands of Western imperialism but at the hands of the Russian and Japanese as well. But the Qing empire was also beset with serious internal rebellion, which fed into its external vulnerabilities. The description of this dark period for China as a ‘century of humiliation’ is more than apt.

The First Opium War was soon followed by the Second Opium War of 1856–60, with British forces joining with the French to engage in what came to be known as the Arrow War. This followed Chinese officials boarding a British ship named Arrow to arrest a Chinese citizen from the ship. The French joined the British in attacking the Qing forces on the pretext of avenging the murder of a French missionary earlier in 1856. The defeat of the Qing led to the even more humiliating Treaty of Tianjin, concluded in 1858, by which major concessions were extracted by the victorious powers. These included the opening of several other Chinese ports for trade, the right to navigate inland along the Yangzi river, the right to travel to all parts of the Qing empire, removal of all restrictions on missionary activities throughout China and legalization of import of opium into the country. China also agreed to the setting up of foreign legations in